

Case Study
Brand Positioning
And Strategy



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Branding and Marketing - CSM
Repositioning of Brand and Perception / Strategy Development

*The importance of branding and strategy.
It is only a “build it and they will come” in the movies.*

Situation:

CSM Hospitality, a privately held company that had operations in hotels, multi-family living, commercial and retail real estate wanted to elevate their awareness, increase the visibility, increase their footprint within assets and their desirability as a top employer.

The perception of the company had made it difficult to attract and retain talent and be at the table in real estate deals where they wanted to grow. Strategy was being done in silos where it was cumbersome and confusing to see impact and results.

The engagement was based on three critical points. 1- the position for the brand, 2- the strategy development in key areas; Development, Human Resources, Revenue Effectiveness and PR that used the positioning as the ‘true north’, 3- the tactics that drove outcomes.

Process:

1- Finding the Brand Position:

- We led them on a journey to position their brand around three key areas; 1- What does their customers want, 2- what is the why that is their driving force, and 3- what is the white space that is their differentiator to drive business.

Example: CSM wasn’t positioned around any battle cry or vision. They didn’t have a ‘True North of why they do what they do. Other than to generate revenue, which is a result, not their ‘why’. Nor did they have an idea of what made them different against other firms. Lastly, they talked about themselves and what they do, rather than having the point of view of the customer or employee.

What we brought: We designed a positioning statement with their engagement and involvement to create momentum and stickiness to the entire team. There was research, interviews with the critical leaders, competitive analysis, interviews with their aspirational customers. This gave us the data to create an effective and differentiated positioning that were able to leverage in those key areas.

The position:

We were born and bred in the Midwest, where we are proud of our values and work ethic. But don't underestimate us, we are fast and agile. We have swagger, but we just don't need to show it off.

Visualize, Collaborate, Realize.

2- Creating the Strategy-

- CSM needed to have one source of truth in strategy development and deployment, vs. a bifurcated approach. They needed to show up whole and best of class. Rather than two separate divisions working under one roof. Strategy was based on data and analysis of where they needed to focus to drive to the goal.

Example: Because the divisions were siloed the presence, awareness, and strategy were all driving towards different goals and the outcomes weren't as impactful to the larger organization. What we see in our customers they are focused on the story of why there are where they are, rather than the data-driven analysis to get you to the goal.

What we brought: Cascading off of our Brand Positioning we helped CSM to define, develop and execute strategy, in the three critical areas (Development, Human Resources, Revenue Effectiveness, and Public Relations) was key to moving the organization forward.

Why is this so important? What we saw was a great deal of activity, but little showed or was related to a vision, much less results. Checking off a 'to-do' list doesn't move an organization forward. It just checks off the boxes. A lot of things being done, but little was moving the needle.

3- Development of tactics

- There were a lot of lists what the teams were doing, but very little correlated to outcome and performance.

Example: Teams were comfortable in what they had always done, yet expected to get to new and ambitious goals. Bringing in outside thinking to challenge the status quo, was necessary. Our focus was to help to build that foundation and framework, so they were able to replicate. Repeatable Results are key to sustainability.

What we did: We worked beside each team to build out the tactics that will get us to our goals. This did two things for CSM. 1- it cut through quickly areas of opportunity and ineffectiveness. 2- Quickened results. Time was focused on work that mattered to the goal. Seems obvious, yet uncommon.

Outcome:

Some key outcomes from the CSM Branding and Strategy work

- Revenue Effectiveness strategy that RevPAR growth YOY of 9 basis points for total estate, all from ADR (same-store sales).
- Development positioning of **Visualize**, what we can do together, **Collaborate** with the best of breed, **Realize** returns.
 - CSM was able to dispose of 14 hotels and enter into a more profitable management contract that they couldn't have achieved prior to the awareness and perception
 - 5 new hotel deals in the pipeline and built, the largest development pipeline of since inception.
- Attraction of new employees using the **Visualize a new Future; Collaborate with best of breed, Realize your potential** employee engagement campaign.
- PR program that was able to be shared across all mediums from print to social media creating awareness of brand.

**References Available
Upon Request**

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